



Life



Fibromyalgia



Disability



Health



Covid-19



My World Changed

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Fibromyalgia, COVID-19 and Human limits: Berta Kaguako Breaks down her Battles

I went out for my usual morning jog, and that evening I started experiencing pain in my feet. I initially thought I pulled a muscle and ignored it. However, the pain persisted, making it difficult to even stand or place my feet on the floor, gradually becoming unbearable.

After various consultations, I found out I had Morton's Neuroma (benign in nerves of feet) in both feet, resulting in multiple surgeries (11) and procedures (2) over the course of roughly 5 years, as when one neuroma was removed another grew in its place, with both legs. I finally saw a consultant in the UK who clipped & cauterised my nerves, preventing them from growing back. As I was informed, nerves have memory cells, and they keep growing back with a new neuroma as a result. My last surgery was in December 2015, and after recovering from my last surgery, my health took a toll for the worse.

This was a start to my long journey of battling with Fibromyalgia.

Fibromyalgia Diagnosis

Fibromyalgia syndrome (FMS) is a disorder which consists of widespread musculoskeletal pain, and the body attacking the muscles, which includes the heart & brain.



Six months after my final surgery, I noticed a build-up of symptoms and was seen by neurology who explained, they believe I have fibromyalgia, due to the trauma my body went through having aggressive treatment in a short period of time.

There was no explanation provided regarding fibromyalgia or its associated symptoms, nor was there guidance on managing it. The advice merely suggested prioritising rest and avoiding overexertion, emphasising the impact these actions can have on how one's body feels the following day.

My doctors provided little assistance and described fibromyalgia as a complex condition. It's classified as autoimmune, yet it primarily affects the musculoskeletal and neurological systems, placing it in a unique category. There's limited understanding of its effects and origins, with only a few theories such as genetic factors or bodily trauma, like in my situation.

Since they were uncertain about the appropriate treatment, they prescribed medications to alleviate the symptoms. With a lot of symptoms to manage, I found myself juggling different medications, a process I disliked due to their side effects

mirroring my symptoms, making me feel even worse. Moreover, I had to take large doses to experience any relief.

As a result, I did a lot of research because there's so much contradicting information, but I got an overall idea of my symptoms. I grew up in a home where we preferred herbal medicines over pharmaceuticals, so when opiate medications were not supporting to manage my pain, I started looking at incorporating more herbal medicine into my lifestyle/diet. After 2 years of experimenting with my body, I started to fix a combination of exercise, herbs, spices, diet, acupuncture, massage, organic pain relief patches including CBD, remedies made with essential oils, and meditation helped me drive my condition into remission and by 2017, I was starting to feel like myself again.

Although my condition was in remission, it is worth noting that my body was still in constant pain just 2/10 pain and all my symptoms were still present and I still had flare ups if I pushed my body too much and/or during menstruation, it would induce a flare-up; which is a manifestation of all the symptoms at once with intensity. I also started including cannabis based medical products replacing my opiates with them, and used these to manage flare ups, since 2019.

Symptoms

Associated with Fibromyalgia, I have the following symptoms:

- Widespread pain—every fibre of my being, my face, my eyeballs and sockets, my inner ears, my lips, my jaw, parts of my body that I didn't even know exist hurt
- Chronic fatigue—I am always exhausted and when I have slept well, I am tired, but either way, I rarely have energy
- Mental health—pain impacts your mental health, as well the pressure of sustain healthy lifestyle, and for me the anxiety of how much worse I can be and what kind of quality of life I would have (which often leaves you feeling suicidal and hopeless)
- Insomnia — I cannot sleep, mainly because I am woken up by the pain, once the pain medications have worn off
- Cognitive processing functions — I have memory loss, I get brain fog, I forget words and meanings, confusion, discombobulation, disassociate, slurred

speech, can sometimes be in a dream like state, do not notice or see things right in front of me (as my brain has not processed it, this can even be people)

- Brain aches—I get headaches, migraines and something else that can only be described as a brain ache, these are consistent and swap between the 3
- Skin — my skin scaly, drying and peeling: legs, arms, chest and face (mostly legs)
- Hot & cold flashes, incontinence, tremors, twitching, restless legs
- Sensitivity to stimulus: sound, light, smell, taste & touch, tinnitus

Treatment & challenges

Since January 2022, my health severely declined, and I spent a lot of time in and out of the GP (doctors office), where I was shocked to receive disturbing support.

Not only did my GP disregard the changes to my physical health, but they also then tried to use my mental health against me and informed me that its my anxiety and everything was in my head.

It was a year of advocating for myself with various services, as my GP informed other services that I was fine, and it's all in my head, despite an existing diagnosis and evidence of long-covid. I was eventually saved by a pain consultant who recognised there was something wrong and put pressure on services to take me seriously.

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As a result, Rheumatology reviewed me and arrogantly re-diagnosed me with fibromyalgia, as they were trying to discharge me, however I am still open to them, as I am having treatment for arthritis (which is a whole other story). Once it was confirmed that my condition is out of remission and has progressed, we finally started doing treatment again, however as my condition is much worse, the same

opiates were now barely touching the pain, and I was taking 12 tramadol, 10 naproxen & 10 paracetamols daily, just to be comfortable enough to lay in bed, these meds were just to manage the pain, and I was on other medications for the other symptoms such as tizanidine, gabapentin etc.

I had to stop working, no more socialising and seeing friends, basically I could barely physically leave my bed, nor could I care for my hygiene or dietary needs. I was told about medical cannabis by a friend who is a doctor, working in the field, so I started them from early 2019, where I took them as and when needed.

However, after my health declined, I was recommended to take the medications more regularly in place of the opiates and other medications I was on, which by this point was roughly 9 different types of medications. After switching over after 6 months, I gradually swapped over and then started feeling 75% symptom relief. This enabled me to get some of my life back, work part time (mostly from home) and can engage in physiotherapy and take back control of my health care routine. I started doing lidocaine infusions to suppress the nervous system, which is working, and I am slowly starting to see the benefits, and I am back to my regular healthcare routine, this year from Jan 2024. I still unfortunately have more recovery to go, but my symptoms are managed and making it easier to push through and do all the work you need to, to take care of your health and wellbeing.

Long-COVID

COMPLETED LONG COVID

14:59

46%

← ^_Nuffield^_ Health Rehab...

Hi Berta,

Well done on completing your Rehabilitation programme.

We hope that the last 12 weeks have supported you with your recovery and helped you to return to good health and wellbeing.

It's really important that we can measure the impact the programme has made on your health and wellbeing, so please complete the end-point questionnaire [here](#).

We'd also like feedback on your overall experience of the programme. A quick survey can be accessed [here](#).

Don't forget you continue to have 3 months free membership. Discuss with your Rehabilitation Specialist which classes and services may be suitable for you, to support your continued recovery.

If you have any questions, please contact your Rehabilitation Specialist directly.

Best wishes,

Nuffield Health



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STORY OF MY LIFE, EVERYDAY APPOINTMENTS!



VITAMINS AND MEDS ROUTINE

Appointments and Medicines became close friends

Since 2017, I have been doing well managing my symptoms and getting my life back on track, re-establishing friendships, as my condition did consume the majority of

my time and energy, as you have to have a vigorous routine to drive your condition into remission.

As a result, you often do not have the energy to socialise and have very little patience, due to the exhaustion, and generally feeling overwhelmed the majority of the time.

In 2020, we experienced the pandemic, and I got COVID multiple times, however, after the 3rd time, I started experiencing a resurfacing of all of my underlying health conditions, including fibromyalgia.

All my symptoms came flooding back overnight and progressively worsened to the point where I was unable to function at all, as my pain was averaging 7/10 and all my symptoms were present 24/7.

I could not remember anything, I could not eat, I could not sleep, I was in agonising pain to the point where I could not stand, I would faint regularly, even whilst cooking and have burnt the kitchen several times either due to fainting or forgetting that I was cooking. I had lost significant weight and was very weak. I could barely lift my arms, let alone my entire body, I physically felt fatigued. These are just a few of the ways my symptoms impacted me, but it takes your life from you, you do not have the ability to sustain anything in your life, including your personal hygiene, let alone anything else.

Conclusion

Fibromyalgia is as real as it gets.

Having all of these symptoms and trying to navigate your way through life is quite challenging, I adapted a lot of tips and tricks over the years, an example, I have to ask people to speak up often, as I have to hear them over the headache and ringing

in my ears or making sure that when making plans with friends, we are somewhere seated at all times, and there is a 50% chance that I will cancel.

At my worst, I could not think, eat, sleep, speak or even open my eyes for too long due to the agonising pain of the light on my eyes. All your symptoms impact you in at least 50 ways each, it takes over your world and is debilitating, no one wants to live like this, we all just pray to have what you would consider a normal life, and this can only be done through treatment and support and recognising that fibromyalgia is a real disease, with a real impact to your life and wellbeing.



BERTA HAGUAHO IS A HEALTH AND SOCIAL CARE CONSULTANT WITH A BACKGROUND IN MENTAL HEALTH, SUBSTANCE MISUSE AND CHILDREN & FAMILIES; IN BOTH A THERAPEUTIC AND SENIOR MANAGEMENT CAPACITY.

BERTA IS ALSO A PATIENT USING CANNABIS BASED MEDICAL PRODUCTS (CBMPS), TO MANAGE HER COMPLEX HEALTH NEEDS AND ADVOCATES FOR CBMPS AS A VIABLE SYMPTOM RELIEVER MEDICATION FOR UNMET CLINICAL HEALTH NEEDS OR AS AN ALTERNATIVE TO CONVENTIONAL PHARMACOLOGICAL MEDICINES ❤️

Berta Kaguako is a Health and Social Care Consultant with a background in Mental Health, Substance Misuse and Children & Families; in both a therapeutic and senior management capacity.

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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.
